Know What You're Taking Over When Your Care Consultant Steps Back

Four prompts to list what you think is moving to the family and what should stay with professionals, name the support you'd want to ask about, describe the changes that would mean calling for help, and write the questions to settle before anything changes.

Where you are

Mom's care has settled into a routine, and your care consultant has raised the idea of stepping back from the week-to-week coordination. You want to be able to handle it. You also don't want to find out in a bad week that you can't reach anyone.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say which tasks you believe are moving to the family and which should stay with professionals, name the kind of support you'd want to ask about, and describe the changes that would send you back for help.

A one-page handoff question sheet with headings: What we think we're taking over, What should stay with professionals, Support we want to ask about, Changes that would send us back for help, and Questions to settle before anything changes.

Before you start

- Your notes on what your care consultant has been handling for Mom, or the list from the Family Training guide if you did it.
- The names of the family lead and whoever would step in for them.
- Anything your care consultant has already said about what she offers after a handoff. You don't need to have asked yet.

PROMPT 1

Sort what moves and what stays, as questions

WHY THIS MATTERS

'Taking over' is vague enough to hide a dozen tasks nobody agreed to. Writing each one as a question keeps the family from assuming something has transferred when it hasn't.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of what your care consultant has been handling and what the doctors, aides, and other providers handle.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Our care consultant is talking about stepping back from coordinating my mother's care week to week. Here is my list of what she has been handling, and what the doctors, aides, and other providers handle:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Sort it into three columns: WE THINK THIS MOVES TO THE FAMILY, WE THINK THIS STAYS WITH A PROFESSIONAL, and NOT SURE. Anything that is clinical care or a provider's own duty goes in the second column. Write every item as a question to confirm, for example 'Is the family taking over scheduling the quarterly review?' rather than a statement. Do not decide any of this for us or tell us whether we are ready.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A long NOT SURE column, which is normal and is the agenda for the handoff conversation.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask the family backup to read the first column and say which items they could cover if the lead were away.

PROMPT 2

Name the support you'd want to ask about

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families often assume the consultant will 'still be around' and the consultant assumes the family knows what that means. Neither assumption survives the first difficult month.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What you think you'd want from your care consultant afterward, and anything she has mentioned offering.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family thinks we'd want from our care consultant after she steps back, and anything she has mentioned offering:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Help me turn this into questions rather than assumptions. For each kind of support I mention, such as an occasional check-in, help before a care meeting, a group, or nothing scheduled, write down what we'd hope it would include and then three questions to ask her: what is covered, how we would reach her and how quickly she answers, and what it costs. Add a line reminding us that

> none of this exists until she confirms it. Do not promise any of it is available, and do not assume she will be reachable in an emergency.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The questions about reach and response time, which families forget to ask until they need the answer.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put the questions in an email to your care consultant, or save them for the next meeting.

PROMPT 3

Describe what would send you back for help

WHY THIS MATTERS

The worst time to decide whether something is serious enough to call about is while it is happening. A short list made on a calm day does that thinking for you.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What has gone wrong before with Mom's care, and what you worry about.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I want to know ahead of time what would mean my family should ask for help again, instead of figuring it out in a hard week. Here is what has gone wrong before with my mother's care and what I worry about:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Make a table with two columns: A CHANGE WE MIGHT NOTICE and WHO WE'D PROBABLY ASK, with the second column phrased as a question such as 'care consultant?' or 'her doctor?' or 'the agency?'. Group the changes into three sets: changes in my mother, changes in the care arrangement, and changes in the family, including the lead being unavailable. Keep a separate line stating that anything urgent goes to emergency services or her doctor, not to a coach or a group. Do not define what counts as an emergency.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Changes in the family, especially the lead getting sick or burned out, which families rarely put in this table.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the table to your care consultant and ask her to correct the second column.

PROMPT 4

Write the questions to settle before anything changes

WHY THIS MATTERS

This page is your side of the handoff conversation, not the handoff. It tells your care consultant what the family wants, what it wonders, and what it would need to see, and leaves the agreeing to the two of you.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've gathered about my mother's care coordination moving toward the family:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with five headings: WHAT WE THINK WE'RE TAKING OVER, WHAT SHOULD STAY WITH PROFESSIONALS, SUPPORT WE WANT TO ASK ABOUT, CHANGES THAT WOULD SEND US BACK FOR HELP, and QUESTIONS TO SETTLE BEFORE ANYTHING CHANGES. Under the last heading, gather the open items, including how we'd want to confirm we can actually do the tasks and not just describe them, and when we'd want to review how it's going. Keep the headings tentative; this is our side of a conversation, not an agreement. Do not write an agreement, set a handoff date, or state that we are ready.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that says what the family wants and wonders, and leaves the deciding to the conversation.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Bring the page to your care consultant; the handoff, if there is one, gets agreed there.

Keep the whole picture in one place.

When coordination shifts toward the family, the file matters more than ever. The care interview organizes Mom's situation into a Family Care Profile, a single starting document the family lead, the backup, and any professional you work with can all return to.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›